Model Evaluation Plan: Evaluating ASR Robustness Under Overlapping English Speech

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Chapter 1

Introduction

Automatic speech recognition (ASR) has improved substantially in recent years due to advances in deep learning, large-scale training data, and computational resources. However, performance remains much less reliable in realistic conversational settings, particularly when multiple speakers overlap, and background noise is present. To develop and evaluate models under these conditions, robust, realistic datasets are needed. The AMI meeting corpus [1] and the CHIME-6 dataset [2] provide important examples of real-world multi-speaker datasets with realistic, detailed annotations.

Two major factors that degrade ASR performance are overlapping speech and environmental noise. Both are common in natural human conversation [3, 4]. Overlapping speech is the time interval during which two or more speakers speak simultaneously. At the same time, background noise is any unintended sound that does not contribute to the conversation. Overlapping speech violates the single-active-speaker assumption underlying many conventional ASR systems. Natural conversations often involve single-speaker segments and partially overlapping regions [3], where standard metrics such as word error rate (WER) might fail to reflect the accuracy [5, 6]. AS a result, overlap-aware and speaker-aware measures such as concatenated minimum-permutation WER (cpWER), Optimal Reference Combination WER (ORC-WER), and diarisation invariant cpWER (DI-cpWER) are proposed [7].

Due to the difficulties and cost of collecting and annotating real-world multi-speaker datasets, synthetic mixtures have emerged as an important alternative. Existing datasets have improved realism by adding ambient noise, reverberation and increasing the diversity of recording conditions and scenarios. However, most were fixed rather than flexible for downstream training to systematically produce more data and varying overlap, noise, duration and speaker count.

Despite this progress, a practical gap remains. Real meeting conversations preserve natural patterns, but this same naturalness poses lexical and acoustic challenges, limiting control over the degradation factors during training and evaluation. On the other hand, existing synthetic datasets are easier to manipulate, but they are typically built with fixed or partially controlled parameters. As a result, it remains difficult to isolate how factors such as overlap ratio, signal-to-noise ratio, mixture duration and speaker count individually and jointly affect ASR performance.

This dissertation addresses the gap by introducing a synthetic mixture generation framework that takes clean speaker recordings, transcription and noise recording as input and outputs mixtures with a user-specified overlap ratio, signal-to-noise ratio, audio length and speaker count, along with timestamped transcripts. Utilising this framework, this study investigates three main questions: how ASR performance changes with overlap and noise, how transferable is the trend observed in synthetic data to real-world, and how publicly available ASR models compare under different conditions.

This framework provides more transparency and information in model evaluation by separating different conditions by degradation factors. In the case where robustness changes with degradation conditions, single-point evaluation becomes underrepresentative. Hence, instead

of simply reporting under a single dataset, this framework provides an opportunity to analyse how different models behave in a range of different conditions, identifying the strengths and weaknesses of different models.

The structure of the dissertation is as follows: Chapter 2 reviews the related work on ASR robustness, multi-speaker datasets and evaluation metrics. Chapter 3 describes architectural design choicesused in the experiments. Chapter 4 details the experimental design, including the generation of synthetic mixtures and the evaluation on real-world data. Chapter 5 outlines and reports the results of experiments. Chapter 6 discusses the implications of the findings, limitations of the study and directions for future work. Finally, Chapter 7 concludes the dissertation by summarising the key contributions and insights gained from the research.

Chapter 2

Literature Review

This chapter reviews the literature relevant to evaluating the robustness of automatic speech recognition (ASR) to overlapping speech. It is structured into three sections. The first section summarises established knowledge about multi-speaker datasets, synthetic mixture generation, overlap modelling, evaluation metrics and ASR architectures. The second section identifies the primary gaps motivating this dissertation. That includes the fact that existing resources do not jointly provide realistic overlap, factor-level control, and fair evaluation when comparing references and hypotheses with different structures. The third section explores recent work that has attempted to address these gaps through more realistic synthesis, more advanced pipelines and end-to-end ASR.

2.1 Foundational Knowledge

2.1.1 Multi-Speaker Corpora for ASR Research

Audio transcription research has depended on a relatively small set of corpora that preserve the acoustic and interactional realism of natural conversations. The *AMI Meeting Corpus* is one of the foundational resources for multi-speaker ASR because it provides approximately 100 hours of monitored meetings with rich annotations and a variety of naturally occurring and scenario-driven interactions [8]. The *CHiME-6* challenge further extended that problem into distant multi-microphone, unsegmented recordings in home environments, introducing a benchmark where diarisation and recognition are performed under noise, reverberation and spontaneous conversational turn-taking [9].

These datasets are foundational to ASR research because they retain the properties that are essential for downstream evaluation and application, like realistic microphone recording conditions, speaker interruptions, incomplete sentences and natural overlap. They together represent the trade-off between ecological validity and controlability. The real datasets preserve natural overlap patterns, acoustic effects and turn-taking, but they do not allow independent control of degradation factors. Inversely, synthetic datasets allow for precise control of factors but often lose the realism of natural conversation. This dissertation is designed to contribute to the middle ground, balancing realism and control.

Therefore, synthetic mixture generation has become a common technique in robust speech research. Earlier speech-separation datasets were often built by randomly mixing utterances under simplified conditions, but later datasets have progressively introduced realism by adding environmental noise, reverberation, corpus diversity and lexical continuity. *WHAM!* added real ambient noise and argued that clean, fully overlapped benchmarks were too narrow for realistic evaluation [10]. *WHAMR!* enhanced this by adding reverberation, modelling the spectral and temporal smearing that arises in indoor environments [11]. *LibriCSS* then provided a more generalised alternative to wsj0-2mix-based datasets like *WHAM!* with mixture derived from

LibriSpeech [3]. Finally, *LibriMix* extended this by mixing in VCTK speech, increasing the total length and thereby making it more suitable for training purposes [12]. The field has provided a rich set of resources for ASR research, but there is yet to be a framework that allows customised manipulation of overlap, noise, duration and speaker count in a reuseable way for generating synthetic mixtures.

2.1.2 Overlap Modelling and Evaluation Metrics for Multi-Speaker ASR

In this literature, the overlap ratio is a useful way to measure and control mixture difficulty. In LibriCSS, the overlap ratio is defined as the total duration of the overlapped region divided by the total speech duration [3]. This is methodologically important because natural conversation is not uniformly overlapped. It is often varied between different dialogue contexts [13]. A benchmark that reduces these contexts into a single average condition hides what a model is actually robust to and what it is not. The evolution from a simple fully overlapped mixture to realistically partially overlapped speech signified an important progress in realism, showing the increasing emphasis on treating overlap as an experimental variable rather than a marginal condition [14].

In ASR evaluation, the choice of metric can influence the weights of different aspects considered. In single-speaker ASR, word error rate (WER) is the standard metric, but in multi-speaker and overlapping settings, its calculation and interpretation are problematic. Galibert [15] shows that classical implementations of WER and diarisation error rate (DER) that were designed for single-speaker speech need to be generalised and adapted to multi-speaker conditions to remain meaningful. Several recent works have formalised the metric for multi-speaker transcription in different aspects. von Neumann et al. [16] shows that variants like cpWER or ORC-WER can be understood within a wider framework of long-form multi-speaker WER, while von Neumann et al. [17] provides a toolkit for computing metrics like WER, cpWER, MIMO-WER and OCR-WER. von Neumann et al. [16] also discusses the separation between speaker-attributed metrics and speaker-agnostic metrics by comparing asclite, OCR-WER, cpWER and MIMO-WER. The conclusion is that lexical recognition, temporal information and speaker attribution are all important factors in multi-speaker ASR evaluation, and that no single metric captures all of these aspects equally well. As a result, the choice of metrics must therefore be aligned with the application and the specific aspect of robustness being evaluated while methods of comparing mismatched reference and hypothesis structures remain underexplored.

2.1.3 ASR Architectures and Benchmark Systems for Robust Speech Transcription

The model architecture operating on top of these datasets and metrics has evolved substantially. One family of models is the self-supervised encoders like wav2vec-2.0, which show that pretraining on very large unlabeled examples can learn representations that transfer effectively to downstream ASR by fine-tuning on smaller labelled datasets [18]. Another family is the large encoder-decoder models like Whisper, which uses weakly supervised pretraining and focuses on zero-shot transfer to improve robustness [19]. The third family is the conformer and transducer-based architectures like Parakeet that augmented the transformer with convolutional modules to capture both local patterns and global interactions and widely used in streaming ASR [20]. In modern multi-speaker ASR research, these models are often embedded inside complex pipelines that include front-end separation, speaker diarisation and transcription modules [21, 22]. In conclusion, the field already has mature corpora, mixture-generation, evaluation metrics and ASR models. However, the systematic framework for isolating the effects of overlap, noise and other factors under controlled environments remains less mature.

2.2 Establishing a Gap in the Literature

Despite the progress in multi-speaker ASR research, there are still important methodological gaps for this dissertation. Current real meeting corpora are ecologically valid, but they do not function as reusable testbeds in which overlap ratio, signal-to-noise ratio (SNR), clip duration, and speaker count can all be varied independently and systematically [1, 9]. On the other hand, synthetic datasets each solve only part of the problem. For example, WHAM! added noise, WHAMR! added reverberation, LibriMix provided more data and more realistic mixtures [10, 11, 12]. However, none of these resources was designed primarily as a configurable framework for causal analysis of ASR robustness. Hence, they provided many excellent benchmarks, but less support for answering narrow experimental questions about the standalone and interactive effects of degradation factors on ASR performance.

A second gap concerns the evaluation under structural mismatch between references and hypotheses. Recent metric work has clarified how to judge speaker-attributed hypotheses, speaker-agnostic hypotheses and multi-output systems [16, 17, 23]. However, in practice, many strong ASR systems still output a single sequential hypothesis even when the reference is multi-speaker, while overlap benchmark often encode reference speech as concurrent stream [18, 20]. This creates an awkward in-between case. While cpWER and tcpWER are designed for multi-stream references, they assume a speaker-structured hypothesis. ORC-WER is designed to ignore speaker labels and isolate lexical correctness. However, what is not provided is an estimation algorithm tailored to the specific case of comparing a double-stream reference to a single-stream hypothesis.

This dissertation will therefore address two gaps. The first is the absence of a reusable, reconfigurable synthetic mixture generation framework for overlapping speech that can manipulate overlap, noise, duration and speaker count as experimental variables. The second is the absence of an estimation algorithm for the particular evaluation scenario in which a potentially overlapping double-stream reference must be compared with a single-stream hypothesis transcript. The proposed solution is motivated by the second gap. It is to make the evaluation of mismatched reference and hypothesis structure more informative and fair. In conclusion, these problems define the niche of this dissertation: controlled robustness benchmarking for overlapping speech and an evaluation method for mismatched reference and hypothesis structures.

2.3 Recent Advances

2.3.1 Realism and Generalisation in Overlap Modelling

Recent work has attempted to reduce some of these limitations. Some research has focused on improving the realism of synthetic overlap. Yang et al. [14] criticise the standard practice of randomly mixing utterances and propose a more realistic simulation by learning overlap patterns from real conversation, and representing overlap patterns as a sequence of discrete tokens. Their results show that the ASR model trained with a realistic overlap simulation consistently outperforms models trained with random overlap. In the benchmarking direction, Cornell et al. [24] spurs the generalisation across speaker counts, formal vs informal settings, meeting duration, acoustic scenarios and recording configurations. Although they have made valuable progress from optimisation under specific conditions to broader generalisation, improving realism, they have yet to provide systematic frameworks to control overlap, SNR, duration, and speaker count in a clean design.

2.3.2 Integrated Pipelines and End-to-End ASR for Overlapping Speech

A second direction of work has concentrated on integrated meeting-recognition pipelines. [21] shows that an end-to-end modular system that integrates independently trained speech separation,

diarisation and transcription modules can achieve competitive performance on LibriCSS. Chen et al. [25] demonstrate that the combination of continuous speech separation (CSS) and conformer-based ASR can achieve state-of-the-art performance in both single-channel and multi-channel settings on LibriCSS. von Neumann et al. [17] use a pipeline that combines the CSS system with TF-GridNet separation and a speaker-agnostic ASR and achieves outstanding performance on ORC-WER. They also propose a syntactically informed diarisation for turn detection, which results in exceptional performance on cpWER. The strength of these modules is that they treat meeting transcription as an all-in-one problem rather than a pure ASR problem. This, conversely, brings the drawback of ambiguity on the source of improvements, which makes it harder to locate the specific factors that contribute to the improvements and also makes it harder to locate the point of failure.

A third line of work has turned to an end-to-end ASR framework for speaker-attributed modelling. Kanda et al. [26] present a transformer-based end-to-end model that performs speaker counting, speech recognition and speaker identification, reducing the dependence on separated separation and diarisation modules. Chang et al. [27] shows that such a model is susceptible to the mismatch between training and testing conditions and introduces a hypothesis stitcher that fuses multiple hypotheses into a single output to help improve accuracy. Kanda et al. [28] push this further by showing speaker-attributed transcription can be used to derive diarisation output, achieving a comparable diarisation error rate to existing diarisation methods and better if the number of speakers is not known. Conclusively, these studies are important because they treat lexical content and speaker identity as mutually informative independent tasks. On the flip side, they also reveal that since these systems are more specialised, the training assumptions are stronger, and the resulting outputs are less comparable to single-stream ASR baselines.

More recent papers have tried to reduce the gap between theoretical models and practical applications. Cui et al. [29] propose a pipeline for real-life applications that involves voice activity detection (VAD), speaker diarisation (SD), and speaker-attributed ASR (SA-ASR). They show that using VAD results to finetune the SA-ASR model significantly reduces the speaker error rate (SER) and demonstrate that extracting speaker embedding from SD can further improve the SER. Raj et al. [30] push the SURT framework from speaker-agnostic to speaker-attributed ASR by adding a speaker branch and prefixing each chunk with speaker information. Zheng et al. [31] introduces the DNCASR model for joint neural speaker clustering and ASR, effectively addresses overlapping speech and achieves strong cpWER performance on AMI. These studies indicate that the field is moving towards more application-oriented systems of long-form, speaker-consistent and meeting-level transcription. Nonetheless, they still rely on a small set of benchmarks. They therefore match the need for studies that evaluate ASR systems under different controlled conditions.

2.3.3 Unified Metrics for Multi-Speaker ASR Evaluation

Recent literature on ASR metrics provides evolving insights into multi-speaker evaluation. von Neumann et al. [17] contribute to standardising the computation of WER, cpWER, ORC-WER and MIMO-WER as a toolkit. von Neumann et al. [23] contributes to the conceptual framework for clarifying which metrics are suitable for which output structure and which aspect of performance. They also propose efficient approximation algorithms for expensive metrics like ORC-WER and DI-cpWER. These works discourage the default use of a single metric for outputs that embody different assumptions about speaker structure and timing. However, even this more mature scoring literature still treats the metrics primarily as ways of assessing matching systems. It does not directly solve the narrower experimental problem of how to compare double-stream references with single-stream hypotheses. That is, therefore, the space in which the present study makes its methodological contribution.

2.3.4 Summary

Overall, parallel research has advanced in three main directions. It has made the synthetic overlap more realistic rather than purely random. It has strengthened meeting transcription through integrated modular pipelines that combine separation, diarisation, and recognition. It has progressed ASR evaluation metrics towards a more comprehensive approach. However, it still leaves a gap in not having a lightweight, reusable framework for systematically varying degradation factors and the metrics that handle stream-mismatched evaluation. The present dissertation is designed to contribute to that missing middle ground.

Chapter 3

Architectural Design

3.1 Design Objective and Principles

This chapter describes the software architecture for synthetic mixture generation, automatic speech recognition (ASR) inference under controlled identical conditions, evaluation using both established and proposed transcription metrics, and statistical analysis. The following principles guide the design:

- Experimental control: overlap ratio, signal-to-noise ratio, clip duration, speaker count and noise type must be varied independently and systematically.
- Controlled comparison: ASR models must be evaluated under the same set of synthetic mixtures with model-specific decoding.
- Traceability: every result must be traceable to the specific configuration, including source files, offsets, transcripts and inference outputs.
- **Modularity**: all components, including mixture generation, ASR inference, metric computation and statistical analysis, should be self-contained and separable so that new models or metrics can be added without rewriting the system.
- **Reproducibility**: random seeds, libraries and model versions must be recorded so that other researchers can reproduce the experiment.

3.2 System Overview

Figure 3.1 depicts the main pipeline of the system. The system starts from clean speaker audio folders (containing audio from a single speaker, with the speaker ID as the folder name and the corresponding transcripts) and noise audio folders (.wav or .flac, with the noise type as the folder name). A configuration file specifies experimental factors for mixture generation, including the number of mixtures, SNR levels (SNR), overlap ratios, duration, and speaker count (number of unique speakers). The *Mixture Generator* module creates synthetic mixtures based on these configurations and outputs both the audio files and a manifest (containing metadata and transcripts). The mixed audio is fed into the target ASR models for inference. The result hypotheses are scored against the reference transcripts using evaluation metrics. The resulting hypotheses are then evaluated against the reference transcripts using specified evaluation metrics. The final results are analysed and compiled into a final report.

3.2.1 System Boundary and Design Rationale

Table 3.1 summarises the main components of the system and their responsibility. A modular architecture is adopted to allow for flexibility and extensibility, such that each component can

Table 3.1: Summary of the main components in the experimental framework.

Component	Input	Output	Responsibility
Synthetic mixture generation	Overlap ratio, SNR, noise type, speaker count	Synthetic audio, transcripts, and manifest	Generate synthetic audio mixtures that satisfy the specified acoustic and structural conditions.
DSS-WER beam approximation	Double-stream reference and single-stream hypothesis	DSS-WER approximation	Approximate a word error rate that permits interleaving between the two reference streams.
Benchmarking	None	Time statistics for four models	Measure the inference-time cost of each ASR model under a common benchmarking procedure.
Statistical notebook module	Transcriptions and WER values for each model and clip	Statistical plots and tables	Transform raw transcription outputs into statistical summaries, comparisons, and interpretable empirical claims.

function independently. The synthetic mixture generation is separated from the ASR inference to ensure that synthetic mixture generation can also be used for other purposes such as training ASR models, and to allow for the possibility of adding new ASR models without modifying the generation code. The metric computation and statistical analysis are separated to allow for the addition of new metrics or new statistical analyses without modifying the inferencing code. This also keep the raw data so that new analyses can be performed without rerunning the entire system.

3.3 Artifact Structure

3.3.1 Synthetic Audio Manifest Structure

Every clip is recorded in a manifest as a CSV file with metadata and transcripts. The transcript is a sequence of tuples of the form (speaker id, text, start time, end time) for each utterance. Table 3.2 summarise the key fields.

3.3.2 Transcription Output Schema

The output transcription JSON file has the following format:

- **key**: clip ID
- **transcript**: a dictionary of the form `{model name: hypothesis}` for each ASR model, where each hypothesis is a list of tuples of the form (speaker id, text) for each utterance.

3.3.3 Metric Output Schema

The evaluation results are stored in a JSON file with three top-level fields: `summary`, `results`, and `timestamp`. The `summary` field contains aggregate information over the full evaluation run, including the total number of clips processed, the numbers of successful and failed evaluations, and descriptive statistics for the reported metrics. In particular, it stores counts and summary statistics for standard word error rate (WER), DSS-WER, and ORC-WER.

Field	Purpose	Example
`clip_id`	Unique key joining audio, predictions, metrics, and statistics.	`mix_0000104_0.00_2_0_T`
`audio_path`	Relative path to the generated waveform.	`output/audio/mix_000031.wav`
`transcript`	Ordered list of utterances with speaker ID, text, and timestamps.	`[(spk,text,t0,t1),...]`
`source_files`	Provenance of the clean speech segments used.	list of input `.flac` or `.wav` paths
`noise_files`	Provenance of the noise segment(s) used.	list of noise `.flac` or `.wav` paths
`speakers_count`	Number of distinct speakers in the mixture.	`2`
`overlap_ratio_target`	Requested overlap ratio from configuration.	`0.20`
`overlap_ratio_actual`	Realised overlap ratio after scheduling.	`0.20`
`snr_db`	Requested SNR, or `clean` for no added noise.	`7.4`
`noise_type`	Noise category for condition grouping.	`P` (public)

Table 3.2: Recommended manifest schema. The key design principle is that every downstream analysis should be derivable from `clip_id` plus stored metadata.

The `results` field contains a list of per-clip evaluation records. Each record corresponds to one audio clip and takes one of two forms. For an unsuccessful evaluation, the record instead stores the clip identifier, model name, evaluation status, and an error message describing the failure.

Finally, the `timestamp` field records when the output file was generated. This structure separates corpus-level summary statistics from clip-level measurements, while also preserving failure information for later inspection and debugging.

3.4 Synthetic Mixture Generation

The synthetic mixture is the core module of the system. It determines how overlap and noise are controlled. It comprises three steps: (1) **Speaker and clip selection**: randomly select the required number of speakers and clips from the clean speech dataset, (2) **Offset scheduling**: (1) **Offset computation**: calculate the time offsets for each utterance such that the overall overlap ratio approaches the target. (2) **Residual adjustment**: adjust the time offsets calculated to ensure the overall overlap ratio exactly matches the target. (3) **Noise addition**: add noise to the mixture at the specified SNR level. The output of this process will be a set of audio with different speaker counts and overlap ratios as base clips, and each base clip will have variants with different SNR levels. The metadata and transcripts of the mixtures are stored in a manifest file.

3.4.1 Speaker and Clip Selection

This *clip-selection* process takes a target speaker count c and a duration d (minimum duration of final mixed audio), and returns: (1) a sequence of clips satisfying the target speaker count and duration constraints, (2) the corresponding sequence of transcripts.

Figure 3.2 shows the process that is designed to create a sequence of clips with specified speaker count and duration. A set of c speakers is selected at uniform random without replacement. The process iterates until the total duration of the selected clips exceeds the target duration adjusted by the overlap ratio (to account for the overlapping region that is double-counted here). The adjusted total clip duration T_{src} is calculated by:

$$T_{\text{src}} = T_{\text{active}} + T_{\text{overlap}}. \tag{3.1}$$

If the overlap ratio is defined as

$$\text{OVR} = \frac{T_{\text{overlap}}}{T_{\text{active}}}, \tag{3.2}$$

Then the required total source duration is

$$T_{\text{src}} = d(1 + \text{OVR}) \tag{3.3}$$

This formulation is preferable to the naive duration threshold because it accounts for the double-counted time by the overlapping region. Without this, a highly overlapped mixture would have a much shorter duration than the intended target.

A balanced selection is used during the clip selection process. The next speaker is chosen with a probability inversely proportional to the number of clips contributed by each speaker, to balance the number of clips per speaker (with probability 0 for speakers from the previous iteration). The random selection of clips is uniform random with replacement. This process mimics an actual conversation, with speakers taking turns.

3.4.2 Offset Scheduling

This scheduler given a sequence of clips with durations $\ell_1, \ell_2, \ldots, \ell_n$ and overlap ratio ($\text{OVR} \in [0, 1]$), constructs clip starting sample index such that the overlap ratio is exactly as specified, using the given overlap std ratio σ_{OVR}, and clip spacing mean and std (for non-overlapping case).

In the case where the overlap ratio is zero, the start time of each clip is determined by allocating a spacing that is a random sample from a normal distribution $\mathcal{N}(\mu, \text{std})$ where μ and std are the mean and std of the clip spacing specified. In the case where the overlap ratio is greater than zero, the target absolute overlap o^* is

$$o^* = \frac{\text{OVR}}{1 + \text{OVR}} \cdot \sum_{i=1}^{n} \ell_i. \tag{3.4}$$

The total is distributed across the adjacent clips. Let o_i be the overlap between clip i and clip $i + 1$, then the scheduler enforces

$$0 \leq o_i \leq \min(\ell_i, \ell_{i+1}), \qquad \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} o_i = o^*. \tag{3.5}$$

For n clips, the average overlap is

$$\bar{o} = \frac{o^*}{n - 1} \tag{3.6}$$

then each overlap o_i is sampled as

$$o_i = \mathcal{N}(\bar{o}, (\bar{o} \cdot \sigma_{\text{OVR}})^2) \tag{3.7}$$

After that, a residual correction is applied so that the sum of sampled overlaps equals the target overlap exactly. The difference diff $= o^* - \sum$ sampled overlaps. If the difference is greater than zero, we randomly select overlaps that are smaller than the preceding and succeeding clip durations, and add one sample to each selected overlap until the difference is zero. If the difference is negative, we randomly select overlaps greater than zero and subtract one sample until the difference is zero. Finally, the start sample index of each clip is determined by adding the spacing (overlap will be treated as negative spacing).

The start times s_i are then computed recursively as

$$s_1 = 0, \qquad s_i = s_{i-1} + \ell_{i-1} - o_{i-1} \quad \text{for } i = 2, 3, \ldots, n. \tag{3.8}$$

An important architectural design choice here is treating the overlap as a controlled variable. This makes the generator suitable for experimental work rather than just producing plausible mixtures.

3.4.3 Noise Addition

After the clean mixture is generated, environmental noise is added.

The noise addition process takes input of the mixed audio, set of noise audio, noise type and target SNR level ($\mathrm{SNR}_{dB} \in \mathbb{R}$ or clean, measured over active speech time). The noise type can be domestic (D), public (P), transportation (T), nature (N), office (O), street (S), or all (A) (see Section 4.4.1 for more details).

Then, noise audio samples are uniformly sampled from the specified noise type(s) and concatenated until the total length is reached, with excess parts truncated. Let $A_{\text{active speech}}$ be the root mean square (RMS) amplitude of the active speech region, and let A_{noise} be the RMS amplitude of the noise segment before scaling. For a target SNR level of SNR_{dB} defined as

$$\mathrm{SNR}_{dB} = 20 \log_{10} \left(\frac{\mathrm{A}_{\text{active speech}}}{\mathrm{A}_{\text{noise}}} \right), \tag{3.9}$$

The noise is scaled by a factor of

$$\alpha = 10^{-\frac{\mathrm{SNR}_{dB}}{20}} \cdot \frac{A_{\text{active speech}}}{A_{\text{noise}}} \tag{3.10}$$

The active speech region is determined by the RMS of all clips in the mixture.

The final mixture is the sum of the clean mixture and the scaled noise.

$$x_{\text{final}}(t) = x_{\text{speech}}(t) + \alpha x_{\text{noise}}(t) \tag{3.11}$$

The SNR is measured relative to the active speech region to ensure the noise level is accurately proportional to the speech content, preventing long silenct regions from distorting the effective noise level.

This algorithm is designed to support controlled experiments on overlap ratio, SNR level, speaker count, duration and noise type by varying each factor independently. It also supports noise analysis on the same clip with different noise types and SNR levels.

3.5 ASR Inference and Experiment Orchestration

The inference layer consumes the manifest and produces standardised hypotheses for each ASR model. Each ASR backend is wrapped by a common adapter interface, enabling uniform orchestration across models. The wrapper is responsible for:

1. Periodic GPU cache clearing and optional garbage collection to manage memory during large-scale inference.

2. Skipping already transcribed clips by checking the existing JSON file
3. Running inference over a batch of clips
4. Serialising the output into the standardised JSON format
5. Recording runtime and failure information

The adapter is important because the ASR models are heterogeneous. Some return segmented outputs, while some return unsegmented outputs. Some inputs are audio waveforms, while some take file paths. This architecture, therefore, standardises the output format and provides a unified interface. To support resumability, the wrapper checks whether a clip has already been transcribed before running inference. Exceptions are logged per batch, so a single clip failure does not break the entire process. This is practical as when large experiments are executed over days, robustness and resumability are important to prevent loss of progress.

3.5.1 Fairness Controls

The following controls ensure that measured differences are attributed to the ASR models rather than confounding factors:

- **fixed sample rate**: 16kHz for all models, resampling is applied if necessary
- **identical audio**: the same set of audio files is used across all models
- **identical reference**: the same set of reference transcriptions is used across all models
- **text normalisation**: the same text normalisation is applied to both reference and hypothesis before evaluation, including lowercasing and punctuation removal.

3.6 Evaluation Architecture

The evaluation system is a separate architectural block. This is where the dissertation's scientific contribution lies.

3.6.1 Established Metric Modules

The first module computes established metrics, such as WER for single-stream referencing and ORC-WER for multi-stream referencing.

WER

Given a reference transcript and a hypothesis transcript, WER is computed as the Levenshtein distance between the reference and hypothesis:

$$\text{WER} = \frac{\text{lev}(r, h)}{|r|} = \frac{I + D + S}{|r|} \tag{3.12}$$

where I, D and S are the number of insertions, deletions and substitutions required to transform the hypothesis into the reference, and $|r|$ is the number of words in the reference [7].

ORC-WER

The ORC-WER is speaker-agnostic. It computes the minimum WER over all possible segments-to-utterance assignments. It is defined as

$$\mathrm{lev}^{(\mathrm{ORC})} = \min_{\rho_1,\ldots,\rho_J} \sum_{j=1}^{J} \mathrm{lev}\left(\bigoplus_{u\in\rho_j} \mathcal{R}_u,\ \bigoplus_{u'=1}^{U_{\mathcal{H},j}} \mathcal{H}_{j,u'} \right) \tag{3.13}$$

where rho_j contains index pairs of speaker i and utterance u, meaning reference utterance u from speaker i is assigned j-th hypothesis segment. $\bigoplus$ is the concatenation operator.

3.6.2 Proposed Metric Module: Double-Stream Serialised WER (DSS-WER)

The DSS-WER is a proposed metric that extends WER to solve the specific case of double-stream reference transcriptions with single-stream hypotheses. Given two reference streams A and B representing two speakers, and a single-stream hypothesis H, the DSS-WER computes the minimum WER between the hypothesis and any interleaving merging of the two reference streams. Formally, let A and B be a partial order of words, and let R be the set of all possible interleaving mergings of A and B that preserve the partial order. Then the DSS-WER is defined as

$$\text{DSS-WER}(A, B, H) = \min_{r\in R} \mathrm{WER}(r, H). \tag{3.14}$$

Example of DSS-WER vs. WER

Figure 3.4 shows an example where the ordinary concatenated WER and the DSS-WER differ. DSS-WER is able to give zero error for a valid interleaving of the two reference streams, whereas WER penalises the different serialisation order. This illustrates the important distinction between the two metrics and the motivation for the proposed DSS-WER.

However, since the number of possible interleavings grows combinatorially with the length of the reference, the time complexity of computing DSS-WER exactly is $O\left(\binom{|A|+|B|}{|A|} \cdot (|A| + |B|) \cdot |H|\right)$, which is computationally infeasible for long transcripts. Therefore, an efficient approximation algorithm is necessary for practical use. Therefore, we hereby propose an efficient approximation algorithm for DSS-WER.

3.6.3 Beam-Search Approximation for DSS-WER

To evaluate a single hypothesis transcript against two reference speaker streams while allowing interleaving, I implement a beam-search approximation to the minimum levenshtein distance over all valid merges of the two reference chains. Figure 3.5 is the overall flowchart. The full pseudocode is in Appendix A.

Let

$$A = (a_1, a_2, \ldots, a_m), \qquad B = (b_1, b_2, \ldots, b_n), \qquad H = (h_1, h_2, \ldots, h_T) \tag{3.15}$$

denotes the two reference chains and the hypothesis chain.

Normalisation

Each word in the reference and hypothesis is normalised by lowercasing and removing punctuation. This is to ensure that the metric is not affected by mismatches caused by case or punctuation differences rather than recognition errors.

State Definition

A search state is defined as

$$s = (i, j, t), \tag{3.16}$$

where i is the number of words consume from chain A, j is the number of words consumed from chain B, and t is the number of words consumed from the hypothesis H. The initial state is $(0, 0, 0)$ and the terminal states are (m, n, T).

Transition and Cost

For non-terminal states $s = (i, j, t)$, there are up to 5 transitions:

1. **Match / Substitution from** A: if $i < m$ and $t < T$, align a_{i+1} with h_{t+1}, gives

$$(i, j, t) \to (i + 1, j, t + 1), \tag{3.17}$$

   The cost is 0 if $a_{i+1} = h_{t+1}$ and 1 otherwise.

2. **Match / Substitution from** B: if $j < n$ and $t < T$, align b_{j+1} with h_{t+1}, gives

$$(i, j, t) \to (i, j + 1, t + 1), \tag{3.18}$$

   The cost is 0 if $b_{j+1} = h_{t+1}$ and 1 otherwise.

3. **Insertion**: if $t < T$, insert h_{t+1} into the merged sequence, gives

$$(i, j, t) \to (i, j, t + 1), \tag{3.19}$$

   The cost is 1.

4. **Deletion from** A: if $i < m$, delete a_{i+1}, gives

$$(i, j, t) \to (i + 1, j, t), \tag{3.20}$$

   The cost is 1.

5. **Deletion from** B: if $j < n$, delete b_{j+1}, gives

$$(i, j, t) \to (i, j + 1, t), \tag{3.21}$$

   The cost is 1.

These transition preserves the partial order of the two reference chain while allowing any interleaving.

Scoring Function

Each state s maintains the best exact cost $g(s)$ while candidate states are ranked using

$$f(s) = g(s) + \lambda h(s), \tag{3.22}$$

where $\lambda \geq 0$ is a tunable heuristic weight, and $h(s)$ is a lower bound estimate of the remaining cost.

Heuristic Function

The heuristic is the maximum of the following two estimates:

- **minimum remaining edit distance**:

$$h_{\text{length}}(s) = |((m-i) + (n-j) - (T-t))| \tag{3.23}$$

  is the minimum number of insertions or deletions required to consume all remaining words from the references and hypothesis, assuming perfect matches.

- **local bag of words lower bound**:

$$h^{\ell}_{\text{bow}}(s) = \left\lceil \frac{1}{2} \cdot \sum_{w} |\text{count}(w, A_{i+1:i+\ell}) + \text{count}(w, B_{j+1:j+\ell}) - \text{count}(w, H_{t+1:t+\ell})| \right\rceil \tag{3.24}$$

  where $\text{count}(w, S)$ is the number of occurrences of word w in sequence S, and ℓ is the lookahead window size (truncated to the end of the sequence). This is a lower bound because it assumes that the best case where all matching words in the lookahead window can be aligned, and the remaining unmatched words can be perfectly aligned.

The heuristic is then

$$h(s) = \max(h_{\text{length}}(s), h^{\ell}_{\text{bow}}(s)), \tag{3.25}$$

preserving admissibility and take the stronger approximation.

Beam Pruning

At each iteration, all successor states are ranked by $f(s)$ with ties breaker of $g(s)$. The algorithm only keeps a bounded number of candidates. The implementation has two main pruning strategies:

- **adaptive beam size**: the beam size is dynamically adjusted based on the distribution of $f(s)$ scores. Given an ambiguity threshold τ, base beam size B and maximum beam size $B_{\max}$, if number of candidates with $f(s) \leq f_{\text{best}} + \tau$ is greater than $\frac{B}{2}$, beam size is set to $B_{\max}$, and B otherwise. This allows search to be more expansive when best path is more ambiguous, and more aggressively when best path is more clear.

- **stratified beam pruning**: candidates are stratified into different buckets based imbalances in consumption in chain A and chain B (i.e. $i - j$), and a balanced number of candidates are kept from each group. The buckets are defined by $\lfloor (i-j)/\max(1, \text{bucket width}) \rfloor$ (where bucket width is a tunable parameter), then the buckets are ranked by the best $f(s)$ score of each bucket, and candidates are selected in a round-robin manner from the ranked buckets until the beam size is reached. This is to prevent the beam from dominated by similar alignment and increase the diversity of the search.

Bidirectional Search

The search is run in both forward and reverse direction, and the best result from both directions are returned. The reverse direction search can discover better alignment that might be pruned in the forward direction.

Final Output

For best path distance d^* found from both directions, the DSS-WER is computed as

$$\frac{d^*}{m+n} \tag{3.26}$$

In addition, the best path alignment is also returned as a list of tuples of the form (operation, chain used, reference word, hypothesis word). This allows downstream error analysis and hyperparameter tunings.

Complexity

Let

- ℓ be the lookahead window size for the heuristic,
- B be the maximum beam size,
- E be the maximum number of expansions (which is the upper bound of the expansions during the search)

The time complexity is

$$O(E(\ell + B \log B)), \tag{3.27}$$

where there is E expansions, each expansion generates up to 5 sucessors, and each successor requires $O(\ell)$ for heuristic computation and $O(B \log B)$ for sorting during beam pruning. The space complexity is $O(E)$ for storing all expanded states.

3.6.4 Metric Output Schema

All metric results are stored at clip level in a JSON file with the following fields: `clip_id`, `model`, `wer`, `orcwer`, `dsswer`.

3.7 Benchmarking

Inference-time benchmarking was used to compare the operational cost of the ASR systems under a common evaluation protocol. A fixed subset of 100 clips was sampled from the experiment manifest using a fixed random seed, and each model was run on the same sampled set.

The runtime metric recorded was measured using `time.perf_counter()` to capture the total wall-clock time taken for inference on the sampled set. This captures the end-to-end time instead of just the decoding time, as it reflects the actual user experience and operational cost.

Execution was performed on CUDA. The implementation used batch size 100 `parakeet` as it allows batch inferencing, while the other systems were evaluated sequentially on the sampled clips. GPU cache clearing and garbage collection were applied between runs, but GPU memory usage was not logged as an output statistic. Likewise, failed runs were not recorded through a separate structured logging system.

3.8 Real-Data Segmentation and Evaluation Pipeline

A separate pipeline was implemented to evaluate ASR performance on real conversational audio. Speaker-labelled utterances were first loaded from a JSON transcript, converted into timestamped intervals, and sorted chronologically. Fixed-length clips were then constructed from valid utterance boundaries so that no reference utterance was truncated across clip limits.

For each extracted clip, the corresponding waveform segment and reference transcript were written to disk as reusable evaluation artefacts. These clips were then transcribed by the selected ASR models under a common batching procedure, with intermediate outputs cached to JSON in order to support recovery from interrupted runs.

Evaluation was performed clip by clip against the exported references. Where a model returned segmented output, ORC-WER was used; otherwise, standard WER was applied to the flattened hypothesis. The pipeline therefore provided a unified framework for comparing heterogeneous ASR systems on real data while preserving both per-clip results and aggregate summary statistics.

3.9 Statistical Analysis Module

All results from transcription and metric evaluation are stored in a clip-level table indexed by clip ID and model. This table is used in the statistical analysis module.

This module converts raw clip-level scores into statistical claims about the generator and ASR models. The main functionalities include:

- **Descriptive statistics**: summarise the distribution of scores under each model and condition
- **Paired comparisons**: perform paired statistical tests between models evaluated on the same set of clips
- **DSS-WER and WER comparison**: perform paired comparisons between DSS-WER and WER to evaluate the proposed metric

3.10 Design Trade-offs and Limitations

This section discusses the design trade-offs and limitations of the architectural choices.

- **Controlled generation vs natural realism**: the generator is designed to support precise control over factors. This is ideal for scientific experiments but may results in less natural mixtures compared to using actual conversation.
- **Metric accuracy vs simplicity**: the DSS-WER approximation algorithm improves accuracy in capturing transcription errors in double-reference-single-hypothesis cases. It better reflects the transcription quality, but it is more complex and substantially more computationally expensive than WER.

3.11 Reproducibility and Experimental Setup

System Environment

Operating System Ubuntu 22.04

Python Version 3.14.3

GPU NVIDIA GeForce RTX 4070 Laptop GPU with 8GB VRAM

Random Seed 1234

Software dependencies and configuration details are documented in Appendix B

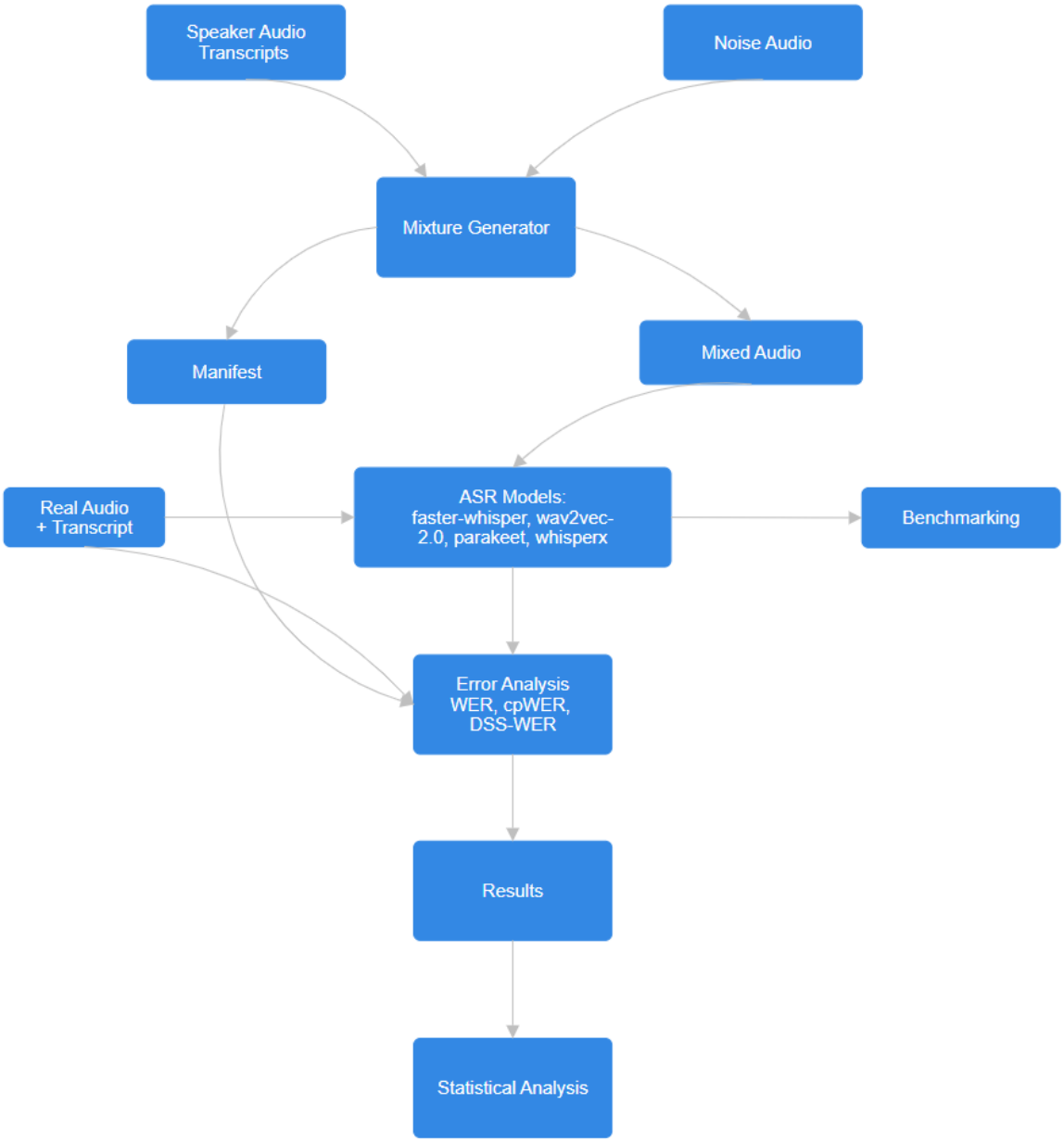


Figure 3.1: High-level data flow through the experimental system. Clean speech and noise recordings were transformed into synthetic mixtures, transcribed by ASR models, and passed to evaluation, benchmarking, and statistical analysis.

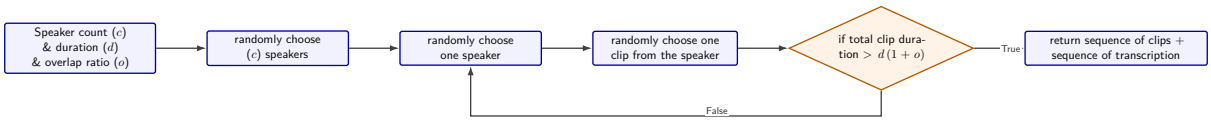


Figure 3.2: Speaker and Clip Selection Process. The stopping criteria are based on the required source duration, which is adjusted by the overlap ratio to account for occupied time by the overlapping region.

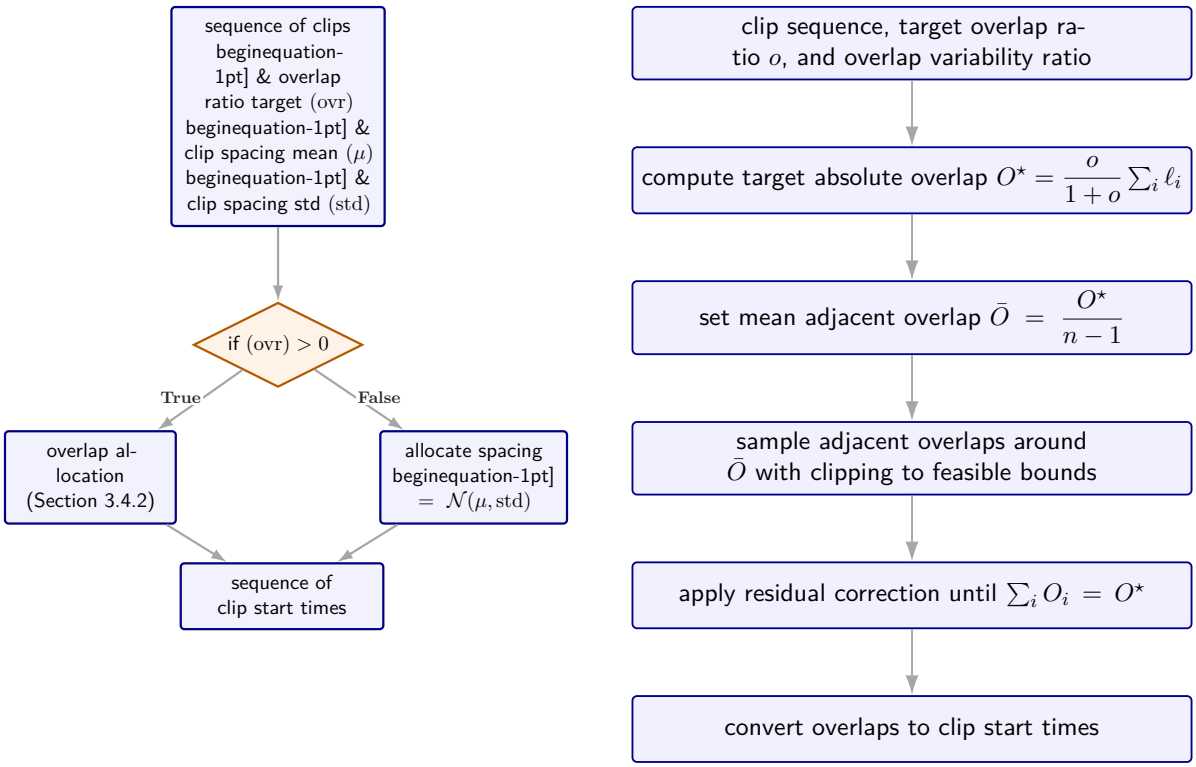
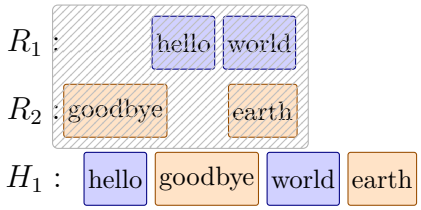
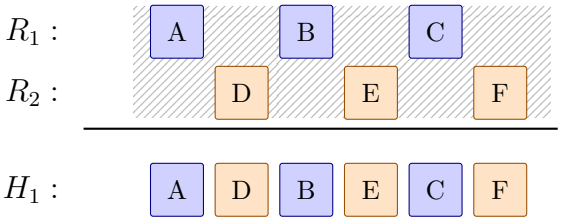


Figure 3.3: Offset Scheduling Process. The left diagram shows the top-level decision flow between non-overlapping and overlapping cases. The diagram on the right shows the overlap allocation process when the overlap ratio is greater than zero.



Metric	Error
WER	1/4
DSS-WER	0/4

(a) A toy lexical example in which the hypothesis forms a valid interleaving of the two reference streams.



Metric	Score
WER	2/6
DSS-WER	0/6

Example: Ordinary WER can over-penalise a hypothesis that is a valid interleaving of multiple reference streams. Here, H_1 = `A D B E C F` preserves the alternating order implied by R_1 and R_2, so DSS-WER assigns zero error. In contrast, ordinary WER compares the hypothesis against a single serialised reference and yields a non-zero score.

(b) An alternating interleaving example where ordinary WER and DSS-WER produce different scores.

Figure 3.4: Examples illustrating the difference between ordinary WER and an interleaving-aware metric. In both cases, the hypothesis is a valid interleaving of the reference streams, so DSS-WER assigns zero error, whereas ordinary WER penalises the mismatch against a single serialised reference.

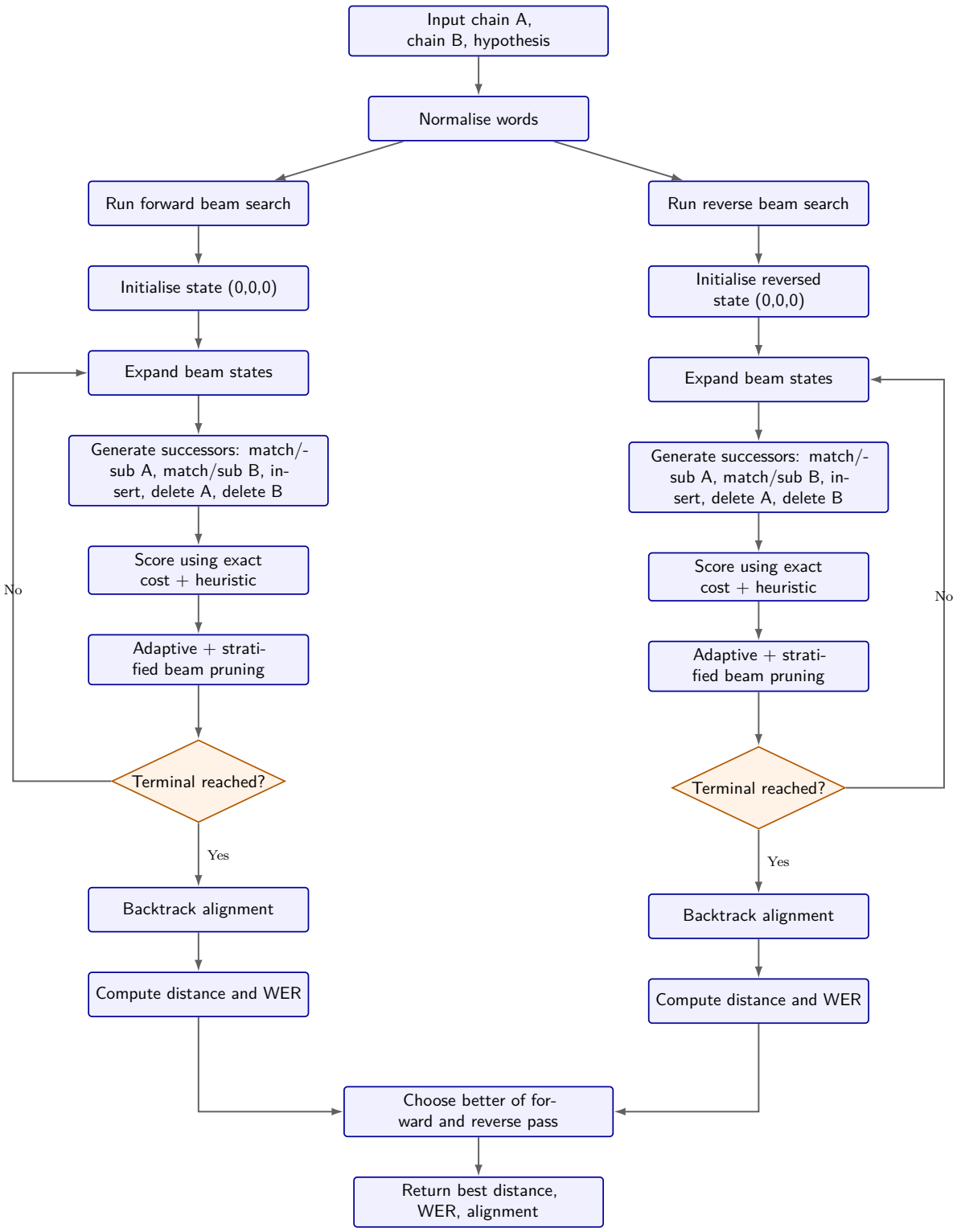


Figure 3.5: High-level flow of the beam-search approximation algorithm for DSS-WER.

Chapter 4

Experimental Design

4.1 Objective and Scope

This chapter specified the empirical design used to evalute the robustness of multiple automatic speech recognition (ASR) transcription models under overlapping speech and addition noise, and to assess the utility and accuracy of the newly proposed Double-Stream Serialisation WER (DSS-WER) when two streams of reference are compared against a single hypothesis. The evaluation is grounded in the structures and pipelines proposed in Chapter 3 and is divided into three tracks.

The first track is the controlled synthetic benchmarking of ASR performance in which overlap ratio, SNR and noise type are manipulated independently. This provides a setting where degradation factors can be isolated and their effects on ASR performance can be causally attributed, while the ASR models can be evaluated under identical conditions for fair comparison. The second track is a real-world data transferability evaluation on CHiME-6, which assesses whether the trends observed in the controlled synthetic mixtures are visible in natural conversational audio with realistic overlap and noise conditions. The third track is a hypothesis testing of the proposed DSS-WER metric, which evaluates whether it provides additional insights and accuracy in quantifying ASR performance under overlapping conditions compared to standard WER.

4.2 Research Questions

RQ1: How do *overlap ratio* and *background noise* affect ASR accuracy under controlled synthetic conditions, and how does this behaviour differ across models?

RQ2: How do publicly available ASR models compare across different overlap and noise operating points?

RQ3: To what extent do trends observed on controlled *synthetic mixtures* transfer to real conversational recordings with natural overlap?

RQ4: Does the proposed double-stream serialisation metric provide a more suitable evaluation than ordinary WER when a two-speaker reference is compared with a single-stream hypothesis?

The final question is accompanied by the following working hypothesis:

$$d_i = M_{\mathrm{DSS},i} - M_{\mathrm{WER},i}, \tag{4.1}$$

where $M_{\mathrm{DSS},i}$ and $M_{\mathrm{WER},i}$ are the DSS-WER and ordinary WER for the i-th clip, is not significantly different from zero across clips.

$$H_0 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] \geq 0 \qquad \text{against} \qquad H_1 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] < 0. \tag{4.2}$$

Rejection of H_0 therefore indicates that the proposed metric yields significantly lower scores than standard WER on average.

H_0 is expected to hold in the case of non-overlapping speech, where the single-stream hypothesis can be directly compared to the single-speaker reference. However, in the case of overlapping speech, H_1 should hold because wer assumes a single reference stream and will penalise interleaving errors that should not be penalised while DSS-WER can recognise the interleaving nature and therefore yield a lower score.

This hypothesis is not intended to imply that DSS-WER is universally superior to WER. This is specific to the evaluation problem studied in this dissertation, where a single-stream hypothesis is compared against a two-stream reference in which two speaker may overlap and transcripts may be interleaved.

4.3 Design Principles

The overall design principle is a repeated measures benchmarking framework. Each synthetic clip is transcribed by the same set of ASR models, and the model comparisons are paired at clip level. Within the synthetic benchmark, acoustic variants are also paired as the generation process first generate a clean base clip and then derives multiple SNR and noise-category variants from the same base. This reduces the variance, makes difference between conditions more attributable to corresponding factors and makes result more interpretable.

Two consideration motivated the choice of experimental factors. First, overlap ratio is treated as the primary factor of interest because it is the central phenomenon of interest in this dissertation and because overlapping speech is a common and challenging condition for ASR. Second, noise is crossed compared with overlap because both noise and overlap often co-occur in real-world conditions.

4.4 Track 1: Controlled Synthetic Benchmark

4.4.1 Speech and Noise Sources

The synthetic mixtures sample clean speech from the source root declared in `speech_roots.txt`, which includes:

- **LibriSpeech train-clean-100** LibriSpeech is a corpus of approximately 100 hours of 16kHz read English speech, prepared by Vassil Panayotov with the assistance of Daniel Povey. The data is derived from read audiobooks from the LibriVox project, and has been carefully segmented and aligned. [32]
- **CSTR VCTK Corpus**: a large-scale speaker recognition dataset containing speech from thousands of speakers, suitable for creating synthetic mixtures with varying overlap and SNR [33].

These datasets provided abundant clean speech with diverse speakers and accurate transcripts. The mixture generator scans these roots for `.wav` or `.flac` files and their corresponding transcripts, and converts multi-channel recordings to mono by channel averaging and resampling to 16kHz if necessary. The background noise is drawn from a local copy of the DEMAND dataset [34]. The DEMAND (Diverse Environments Multichannel Acoustic Noise Database) aims to provide a set of recordings that allow testing of algorithms using real-world noise in a variety of settings. The noise is categorised into three types: domestic (i.e., washroom, kitchen, living room), public (i.e., subway station, office cafeteria, university restaurant) and transportation (i.e., subway, public bus, private passenger vehicle), denoted as D, P, and T respectively. These noise types are broad categories that represent common real-world listening environments where ASR are often used, and small enough to support a manageable clean factorial analysis.

4.4.2 Synthetic Mixture Generation

The mixture generator takes a target overlap ratio, SNR level, noise type, speaker count and target duration as inputs. For the experiment here, the random seed is fixed to 1234, the target duration is set to 60s, speaker count is set to 2 in the configuration for reproducibility and isolation of the effect of OVR, SNR and noise type.

For each base mixture, two speakers are sampled without replacement from the pool of speakers. Utterances are then drawn from each speaker alternatively until the total duration exceed the required duration to realise the target final duration after overlapping. Each utterance also contributed its transcript in which the speaker ID, start and end timestamps are also preserved in a form of

$$(\text{speaker}, \text{text}, t_{\text{start}}, t_{\text{end}}). \tag{4.3}$$

This makes the manifest enable the calculation of any speaker-attributed or time-constrainted metrics in the future.

4.4.3 Noise Addition and SNR Control

The base mixture is then used to derive multiple variants with different noise types and SNR levels. The noise is rescaled by a factor α to achieve the target SNR level, as described in Equation (3.10). The final mixture is then

$$x_{\text{final}}(t) = x_{\text{speech}}(t) + \alpha x_{\text{noise}}(t) \tag{4.4}$$

The same clean base mixture is reused across all SNR and noise-category variants, which makes the variants paired and reduce variance. When SNR is `null` in the configuration, no noise is added and the base mixture is function as clean control condition.

4.4.4 Experimental Conditions and Corpus Size

Table 4.1: Experimental factors and planned levels.

Factor	**Levels**
Overlap ratios (OVRs)	$0\%, 14\%, 20\%, 40\%$
Max concurrent speakers (S)	2
SNR (dB)	clean, 7.4, 0, -5
Noise type	domestic, public, transportation
Audio duration	Synthetic: ≈60s, Real-world: long-form meetings

Table 4.2: Synthetic corpus size in the current manifest.

Target overlap ratio	**Base mixtures**	**Derived variants per base**	**Total clips**
0.00	10	12	120
0.14	100	12	1200
0.20	100	12	1200
0.40	100	12	1200
Total			3720

Table 4.1 documents the levels of the main experimental factors. In the implementation, overlap condition above zero each uses 100 base mixtures, while 0% overlap condition uses 10

base mixtures as control for runtime feasibility. Each base mixture is expanded across all factors SNR × noise type, yielding a total of 3720 corpus summarised in Table 4.2.

The asymmetry in the number of base mixtures between 0% and non-zero overlap conditions is a pragmatic choice to balance the need for a control condition with the computational cost of generating and evaluating a large number of mixtures. It does not invalidate the control condition, but it does mean that the diversity of the 0% overlap condition is lower. Later analysis therefore will treats the 0% overlap condition as a control point rather than a fully representative condition, and the focus will be on the trends across the non-zero overlap conditions.

Overlap Ratios Choice. The overlap ratios are chosen to represent a range of realistic and challenging conditions for ASR:

- 0% is chosen to be the control where it represent completely clean audio in which there is no overlapping.
- 14% is chosen to represent the mean overlap ratio for meetings. The percentage of overlapped words (excluding backchannels like "uh-huh") in meetings is 14.1% [35].
- 20% is chosen to represent the maximum overlap ratio in a natural meeting or casual dinner parties [3] [12].
- 40% is chosen as it is supported by the LibriMix benchmark, which chooses 40% as the maximum overlap ratio. This is chosen to stress-test under high-overlap conditions [3].

Maximum Concurrent Speakers Choice. Speaker count is chosen to be 2 for practicality and to isolate the effect of overlap and noise.

Signal-to-noise Raio Choice. The SNR levels are chosen to represent a range of realistic and challenging noise conditions:

- *clean* is chosen to be the control where it represent clean background with no noise.
- 7.4dB is chosen to represent the noisy environment as it is the mean SNR for noisy environment [36].
- 0db is chosen to represent environment where the noise and speech are equally loud, which is a challenging but realistic condition in very noisy environments.
- -5db is chosen to represent environment where the noise is louder than speech in which even human listeners struggle to understand speech, providing a stress-test condition for ASR.

Noise Type Choice. Domestic, public, and transportation are chosen as they represent different real-world scenarios with varying noise characteristics:

- **Domestic noise** includes kitchen noise when food is being prepared, living room noise and washing room with front-loading washing machine. These noises are commonly found in home environments that a home-based voice assistant would encounter.
- **Public noise** includes noise from main transfer area of subway station, office cafeteria, and university restaurants during lunchtime. These noise represent common public environments where ASR like mobile devices may be used in.
- **Transportation noise** includes noises in subway, public bus and private passenger vehicle. These noises represent common transportation environments where ASR like mobile devices may be used in.

4.5 Track 2: Real-world Data Transferability Evaluation

The real-world data evaluation is intentionally narrower than the synthetic benchmark. Its purpose is to test whether the trends of the findings in synthetic mixtures survives when overlap is natural rather generated.

The implemented real-data scripts is extracted from CHiME-6 evaluation scripts [2], specifically the `S01` session. It is a English multi-channel far field meeting data used in the CHiME-6 Challenge. It is derived from CHiME-5 by fixing some array synchronization errors. It uses the 2 hours long audio and divides it into 100 segments of approximately 60s each by the following rules:

- each clip must be at least 60 s long;
- clip boundaries must lie at utterance boundaries where no other utterance is active at the boundary time;
- only utterances fully contained within the selected time window are kept in the reference.

These design choice avoid clipping utterances mid-sentence, perserving the accuracy of the reference. The 60s duration is such that the duration is similar to that of synthetic mixtures. They mean that the resulting clips are not fully representative of the natural distribution of overlap in the original recording, but that limitation is necessary to enable a clean comparison.

4.6 ASR Models Under Evaluation

Although the framework is designed to be extensible to any ASR model, the evaluation will focus on the following publicly available models that represent a range of model architectures:

- **Faster Whisper** (OpenAI): Faster-whisper is a reimplementation of OpenAI's Whisper model using CTranslate2, which is a fast inference engine for Transformer models. [37]
- **WhisperX** (OpenAI): WhisperX is a ASR model trained on a large dataset of diverse audio [38].
- **Wav2Vec2-Large-960h** (Meta AI): The large model pretrained and fine-tuned on 960 hours of Librispeech on 16kHz sampled speech audio. When using the model make sure that your speech input is also sampled at 16Khz. [39]
- **parakeet-tdt-0.6b-v3** (NVIDIA): parakeet-tdt-0.6b-v3 is a 600-million-parameter multilingual automatic speech recognition (ASR) model designed for high-throughput speech-to-text transcription. [40]

These models are chosen as representation of the mainstream ASR architectures. Faster Whisper and WhisperX are both based on the Whisper architecture, which is a encoder-decoder architecture trained on a large dataset. Wav2Vec-2.0 is an example of self-supervised encoders while Parakeet is an example of the conformer and transducer architecture. The evaluation of these models will provide insights into how different ASR architectures perform under overlapping and noisy conditions, and whether certain architectures are more robust in specific conditions.

4.7 Scoring Metrics

4.7.1 Reference and Hypothesis Structure

For synthetic data, the reference transcripts are loaded from the manifest and reduced to $(speaker, text)$ pairs (removing timestamps) as not all ASR models provide timeed output.

Depending on the model, the hypothesis may be a single stream of text or as multiple segments. This structure determines what metrics can be calculated as some metrics assume a segmented output while some do not. The normalisation function used in scoring is applied to both reference and hypothesis. It strips punctuation and converts text to lowercase. This is to isolate the evaluation to the core lexical robustness under overlap and noise rather than punctuation and casing.

4.7.2 Metrics

Three metrics are used in the synthetic scoring pipeline:

- **Word Error Rate (WER)**: The standard conventional metric for ASR evaluation, computed after concatenating all segments of reference and hypothesis by chronological order
- **Optimal Reference Combination WER (ORC-WER)**: Measures the minimum WER for multi-speaker scenarios across any mapping of hypothesis segements to reference utterances.
- **Multi-Reference Serialisation WER (DSS-WER)**: Proposed metric that computes the minimum edit distance between double reference chains and single hypothesis, allowing any interleaving merge of the two chains.

The DSS-WER implementation is based on the beam-search approximation algorithm in Section 3.6.3 with hyperparameters set to beam width of 64, lookahead of 16, heuristic weight of 0.4, max expansion 220000, max beam width of 128 and with adpative beam size and stratified beam pruning.

4.7.3 Metric Application Rules

The choice of metrics are based on the following rules:

- For single-stream hypothesis output, WER and DSS-WER are used.
- For segmented hypothesis output, all three WER, ORC-WER and DRS-WER are used.

4.8 Experimental Unit and Comparison Strategy

The fundamental unit of comparison is the (clip, model) pair with related metadata and transcript. For synthetic data, the comparison includes:

- comparison across models are paired at clip level as all models are evaluated on the same set of clips;
- comparisons across SNR values are paired becauses noisy variants are derived from the same base mixture;

This pairing structure supports stronger inference than purely between-subjects design. When a model performs different in lower SNR or higher overlap, the degradation or improvement can be attributed more confidently to the change in condition rather than the change in lexical content or other confounding factors.

4.9 Track 3: Hypothesis Testing of DSS-WER

This track evaluates whether the proposed Double-Stream Serialisation WER (DSS-WER) approximation algorithm differs systematically from standard WER, and whether it occurs in the expected settings and direction. Since DSS-WER is designed to relax the strict serialisation assumption of WER, the primary questions are whether DSS-WER yields lower scores than WER in overlapped setting while remaining similar in non-overlapped setting.

Let

$$d_i = M_{\mathrm{DSS},i} - M_{\mathrm{WER},i}, \tag{4.5}$$

where $M_{\mathrm{DSS},i}$ and $M_{\mathrm{WER},i}$ are the DSS-WER approximationand ordinary WER for the i-th clip. A negative value of d_i will therefore indicate that DSS-WER yields a lower score than WER on the i-th clip.

4.9.1 Primary Hypothesis

The main hypothesis is that examines whether DSS-WER approximation is lower than WER on average:

$$H_0 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] \geq 0 \qquad \text{against} \qquad H_1 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] < 0. \tag{4.6}$$

Rejection of H_0 therefore indicates that the proposed metric yields significantly lower scores than WER over the set of clips.

4.9.2 Condition-Specific Hypotheses

To further assess whether the expected advantage of DSS-WER approximation is specific to the overlapping condition, the test is repeated separately for different overlap ratio.

Non-overlapping clips. For clips with no overlap, DSS-WER is expected to behave similarly to WER. Therefore, the hypothesis:

$$H_0 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] = 0 \qquad \text{against} \qquad H_1 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] \neq 0. \tag{4.7}$$

Large d_i will suggest that DSS-WER approximation alters the evaluation even when interleaving is not a factor.

Overlapping clips. For clips with overlap, DSS-WER is expected to be lower than standard WER, since it permits interleaving. Therefore the hypothesis is the same as the primary hypothesis:

$$H_0 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] \geq 0 \qquad \text{against} \qquad H_1 : \ \mathbb{E}[d_i] < 0. \tag{4.8}$$

4.9.3 Test Procedure

Since metrics are calculated at clip level, the comparison is paired where hypothesis testing is conducted on paired differences d_i. A one-sided Monte Carlo permutation test may be used by randomly flipping the signs of the paired differences to generate the null distribution of the test statistic $\bar{d}$. The observed mean

$$T_{\mathrm{obs}} = \bar{d} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} d_i \tag{4.9}$$

is then compared against the null distribution generated by random sign flipping, for $j = 1, ..., N$ permutations:

$$T_{\mathrm{null}}^{(j)} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{i=1}^{N} s_i^{(j)} d_i, \qquad s_i^{(j)} \in \{-1, 1\} \text{ with equal probability.} \tag{4.10}$$

The p-value is calculated as

$$p = \frac{1}{N+1}\left(1 + \sum_{j=1}^{N} 1[T_{\text{null}}^{(j)} \leq T_{\text{obs}}]\right), \tag{4.11}$$

where $1[\cdot]$ is the indicator function. The confidence interval of the mean difference can also be calculated by resampling the paired differences with replacement, calculating the mean difference for each resample and take the 2.5 and 97.5 percentiles of the resampled mean differences as the bounds of the 95% confidence interval.

4.9.4 Interpretation

This analysis does not intend to claim that DSS-WER is universally superior to WER. It test whether DSS-WER yields lower scores than WER in the double-stream reference single-stream hypothesis setting, where DSS-WER is designed to relax the interleaving restriction of WER.

4.10 Reproducibility

The implemented framework traces every results (including synthetic mixture generation, ASR inferencing and metric calculation) to its generating condition. The manifest stores clip identifiers, audio paths, source-file provenance, noise-file provenance, target overlap ratio, realised overlap ratio, SNR, and noise category. Model outputs are written to JSON keyed by clip ID, and evaluation outputs are stored both per clip and per model. Combined with the fixed random seed in the configuration, this provides a reproducible record of how each reported score was obtained.

4.11 Scope and Limitations

The experimental design combines precisely controlled synthetic benchmarking with a narrower but meaningful real-world data evaluation. It separates overlap and noise as explicit variables, preserving the paired comparisons across conditions.

However, the limitation is clear. They are as follows:

- the comparative system only cover four ASR models
- the 0% overlap condition only has 10 base mixtures, which may limit the representativeness of the control condition
- ORC-WER is only calculated for segmented output (faster-whisper and whisperX) as not every model provides segment-level output
- Real-world evaluation only cover one session in CHiME-6 rather than a balanced sampling of real-world conditions

However, these limitations do not invalidate the design. They define the scope of the dissertation and the interpretation of the results.

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Appendix A

Pseudocode for DSS-WER Beam Search

Algorithm 1: DSS-WER-BEAM-2CHAIN(A, B, H)

Input: Reference word chains A, B and hypothesis H
Output: Approximate overlap-aware edit distance and WER

```
initialise search parameters B, λ, M, L;
R_front ← BeamPass(A, B, H, front);
R_tail ← BeamPass(A, B, H, tail);
return the better of R_front and R_tail under lexicographic order (distance, wer)
```

Algorithm 2: BEAMPASS$(A, B, H, \textit{direction})$

Input: Reference chains A, B, hypothesis H, and search direction
Output: One-pass approximate edit distance and WER

```
if direction = front then
    (Â, B̂, Ĥ) ← (A, B, H);
else
    (Â, B̂, Ĥ) ← (reverse(A), reverse(B), reverse(H));
normalise Â, B̂, Ĥ if required;
initialise bestCost[(0,0,0)] ← 0, backpointers, and beam ← {(0,0,0)};
while beam is non-empty and expansion budget not exhausted do
    generate all valid successors of each beam state using: match/substitute against A,
      match/substitute against B, insert, delete from A, and delete from B;
    keep only the best predecessor for each successor state;
    score each successor by
        f(i, j, t) = g(i, j, t) + λ h(i, j, t),                    (A.1)
      where g is accumulated edit cost and h is a lower-bound heuristic based on
      remaining-length mismatch and local bag-of-words mismatch;
    sort candidates by score and prune to the next beam using fixed or adaptive beam
      width, optionally with stratified selection;
read the final state (|Â|, |B̂|, |Ĥ|);
compute WER = distance/(|A| + |B|) when finite;
optionally reconstruct alignment from backpointers;
if direction = tail then
    reverse the recovered alignment;
return distance, WER, and alignment
```

Appendix B

Software Configuration

B.1 Software Dependencies

- numpy 2.4.4
- pandas 3.0.2
- soundfile 0.13.1
- librosa 0.11.0
- faster-whisper 1.2.1
- transformers 4.57.6
- torch 2.8.0
- whisperx 3.8.5

B.2 ASR Models and Configurations

faster-whisper large-v3 model with compute type int8

wav2vec-2.0 wav2vec2-large-960h

parakeet parakeet-tdt-0.6b-v3 with configuration: `right_context_secs=2.0`, `left_context_secs=10.0`, `chunk_secs=10`, `batch_size=1`, decoding=greedy

whisperx large-v2 model with compute type int8